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Medical professionals question parental indifference to letting youngsters drink caffeine

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Many kids and teens may be taking their Flintstones multivitamins, followed later by a caffeinated energy drink.

And their parents know it, according to a National Poll on Children's Health published by C.S. Mott Children's Hospital in May. The Mott Poll reported that 57 percent of parents say they rarely look at caffeine amounts when buying beverages for their teen.

Energy drinks are not just pumped full of caffeine, they are also high in sugar and many contain that controversial red dye No. 40, according to Lisa Andrews, a member of the Ohio Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics.

"Children shouldn't drink caffeinated energy drinks, like Red Bull or Monster, for a few reasons," Ms. Andrews said. "An 8.4-oz. can has as much caffeine as a cup of coffee."

Experts agree that a healthy adult can safely consume 400 milligrams of caffeine a day. For those younger than 18, no more than 100 milligrams is recommended. A Celsius energy drink contains 200 milligrams of caffeine per 12-oz. can.

Caffeine may worsen symptoms of anxiety and could become addictive, Ms. Andrews said. Plus, substantial amounts of sugar are not good for anyone because, at the very least, it could contribute to dental decay.

"Energy drinks contain 27 grams of added sugar, which equates to nearly seven teaspoons," Ms. Andrews, based in Cincinnati, said. "With the childhood obesity crisis, reducing added sugar is key."

Sugar-free options carry their own detrimental impacts.

"The sugar-free versions may have erythritol, an artificial sweetener that may cause gastrointestinal distress and may alter the gut microbiome," Ms. Andrews said.

Finally, an ongoing debate over the use of artificial coloring may be seeing the goal line.

On Aug. 29, the California Legislature passed a first-of-its-kind bill banning six dyes in school foods. That state's governor must either sign or veto it by the end of September. If signed, it is anticipated companies will change their formulas as they will not want to be using different ingredients for different states. The aim is not to ban particular foods or drinks, but to allow companies to adjust their ingredients. If signed, it will go into effect Dec. 31, 2027.

"California has a responsibility to protect our students from chemicals that harm children and interfere with their ability to learn," California Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel said. "As a lawmaker, a parent, and someone who struggled with ADHD, I find it unacceptable that we allow schools to serve foods with additives that are linked to hyperactivity and neurobehavioral harms. This bill will empower schools to better protect the health and well being of our kids and encourage manufacturers to stop using these harmful additives."

The bill would ban the use of red dye No. 40, yellow dyes Nos. 5 and 6, blue dyes Nos. 1 and 2, and green dye No. 3.

Other countries have taken even more restrictive actions. Lithuania, Turkey, and Spain have banned the sale of energy drinks to those younger than 18.

Caffeine intake is one of the questions on a screening sheet nurse practitioner Allyson Konz, of Mercy Health, gives to her pediatric patients.

"I feel marketing has a huge effect on kids," said Ms. Konz, adding that parents can be challenged by the monitoring of their kids' caffeine intake.

"I think it is harder for parents who have kids who drive. When they get gas, they can buy an energy drink," she said.

Anyone who has been on a high-caffeine diet and aims to reduce consumption will want to do that incrementally over at least a few weeks, according to Ms. Konz. When a stimulant is switched off suddenly, headaches and decreased energy can emerge in as few as 12 to 24 hours.

Ms. Konz suggests green tea as an alternative. It has a moderate amount of caffeine and has a host of benefits, including fighting inflammation, lowering blood sugar, and helping to reduce cholesterol levels.

Other options include flavored seltzer water, which has no calories and no artificial sweeteners or colors.

"Low fat milk, 100 percent fruit juice, and water (yup, tap water) are better options for kids," Ms. Andrews said.

Becoming more active also can provide a healthier alternative to caffeine.

"Twenty minutes of exercise a day can increase one's mood and alertness," Ms. Konz said.

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